UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, BERKELEY
DEPARTMENT OF ECONOMICS

PLACEMENT SERVICE: Graduate Office
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ELAINE SHEN

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RESEARCH AND TEACHING FIELDS:

PRIMARY
- Labor Economics
- Household Finance

SECONDARY
- Health Economics
- Behavioral Economics

EDUCATION

	DEGREE	DATE
UC Berkeley	Ph.D. in Economics	2027 (expected)
Georgetown University	B.S. in International Political Economy	2016

Thesis: Essays on Human and Algorithmic Advice
Committee: Stefano DellaVigna, Patrick Kline, Ulrike Malmendier, Jonathan Kolstad

Summa Cum Laude, Phi Beta Kappa; study abroad at University College London

PUBLICATIONS: *(pre-PhD)*

"A Clear Advantage: The Benefits of Transparency to Crisis Recovery"
with George Shambaugh. European Journal of Political Economy, vol. 55 (391–416), 2018

"Insurers and Green Bonds, an Entry Point into Sustainable Investing"
BlackRock, October 2018

WORKING PAPERS:

"The Price of "Free" Advice: Measuring Agency Problems in the Insurance Broker Market" (Job Market Paper)
with Margaret Kallus

Consumers often rely on intermediaries to navigate complex markets, but the very information frictions that make expert advice valuable can leave consumers unable to evaluate the experts themselves. This paper studies how commissions and competition shape agency problems in the Medicare market, where nearly 70 million seniors and people with disabilities choose between complex health insurance plans. We conduct a large-scale audit study in which senior "secret shoppers" make 637 calls to randomly assigned brokers. Brokers steer seniors toward a higher-commission plan in 52% of calls, with substantial heterogeneity; recommendations improve with broker tenure, consistent with learning. Dominated recommendations can cost seniors over $12,000 in present-value lifetime wealth. A natural experiment that eliminates broker commissions reduces steering to the higher-commission plan by 21 percentage points but does not eliminate steering. A randomly assigned treatment designed to increase perceived competition—by signaling that seniors will seek multiple recommendations—causes brokers to recommend lower-priced plans. The response increases consumer surplus when plans are homogeneous, but decreases it when plans differ in coverage. A structural model shows that supply-side reforms, such as equalizing commissions and capping premium markups, generate larger consumer surplus gains than consumer-side policies such as ratings feedback and increased competitive pressure. The findings show that, when consumers cannot evaluate expert advice, competitive pressure can change recommendations without aligning them with consumer interests, making direct reforms to broker incentives a more effective policy lever.

"Dollars and Sense: Self-Selection in Financial Literacy Education"
with Junru Lyu & Laila Voss

A central prediction of human capital theory is that individuals with the highest marginal returns to education should be the most likely to invest in it. We document a stark violation of this prediction in financial literacy education: individuals with the lowest baseline knowledge—and thus the highest potential returns—have the lowest demand for education. Using motivating evidence from a large university personal finance course and a controlled online experiment (n=1,047), we document that demand for financial education is positively correlated with baseline financial literacy, potentially exacerbating pre-existing inequalities. In the lab setting, we identify the mechanism driving this inefficiency. Low-ability individuals systematically mis-calibrate their beliefs, overestimating their baseline knowledge while underestimating the returns to education. To test whether reducing perceived cognitive costs can correct this distortion, we vary the format of the education material, comparing a traditional lecture-style education to video- and AI-based alternatives. While the AI and video versions significantly increase aggregate demand, they fail to correct the adverse selection on ability. Together, the results suggest that supply-side interventions alone may be insufficient to close financial literacy gaps without addressing underlying belief distortions.

"Deadpooling: Strategic Adverse Selection in the Medigap Market"

with Margaret Kallus

This paper studies how firms use subsidiaries to circumvent regulations and profit off inattentive consumers. Linking two decades of Medicare Supplement filings to annual parent–subsidiary ownership records, we document "deadpooling", a novel financial practice where insurers use corporate structure to circumvent regulation and extract rents from high-risk consumers in the Medicare Supplement market. We find that 17.6% of Medigap life-years through 2020 are spent in plans that deadpool, and each year's closures transfer an additional $64.7 million from seniors to insurer profits over the following five years. This extraction is a choice rather than an accounting response to an aging beneficiary pool. Using a natural experiment in which a federal statute effectively closed some plans to new enrollment, we find that deadpooling plans with identical coverage reprice much more aggressively than plans that slowly age in place. Harm to consumers accrues through increased payments to insurers, switching costs, and the change in consumer surplus from beneficiaries priced out of the market. We estimate total harm to be $129.4 million for each year's closures over the following five years and that each dollar of deadpooling markup collected by insurers costs seniors $2.00. We find that expanding switching rights, an intervention that would eliminate this harm in a market with perfectly rational consumers, only reduces deadpooling by 18%. We explain this finding as a consequence of consumer inattention using a demand-side simulation. We examine alternative solutions that do not rely on consumer attention and find that these reduce harm by up to 53%, against a 5% harm reduction from expanded switching rights.

"The Hidden Curriculum"

with Michael Cuna

Despite expanded access to selective colleges, first-generation students often trail their peers in educational and early-career outcomes. We study one mechanism: the hidden curriculum – implicit, unwritten practices critical to educational and career success such as networking. First, we use data from over 70,000 students across 20 public universities to identify a first-generation gap in investment in hidden-curriculum actions. Second, in a field experiment at UC Berkeley, we show an information intervention increases take-up of hidden-curriculum actions by 13pp, closing roughly 77% of the baseline gap. Finally, an online experiment with AI college advisors shows that first- and continuing-generation students exert similar information-acquisition effort, but respond differently to hidden-curriculum nudges. Proactive information about returns eliminates this gap. The results highlight that asymmetric information about potential strategies and returns may prevent equal access from delivering equal opportunity and equal outcomes.

WORK IN PROGRESS:

"Personality Assessment Algorithms in Hiring" (analysis stage)
with Hadar Avivi & Margaret Kallus

"Money Therapy: AI Advice and Financial Decision-Making" (pilot funding and data use agreement secured)
with Emanuel Renkl & William Zhang

"Overconfidence and Information Seeking: Implications for Financial Decision-Making" (funded; pilot fall 2026)
with Vanessa Sticher

"AI, Beliefs, and Job Search" (IRB-approved; pre-registration in progress)
with Marion Carr & Michael Cuna

"Advertising and Persuasion in Medicare Insurance Markets"
with Margaret Kallus

"Insurance Agent Licensure: Turnover, Trends, and Spatial Differences"
with Margaret Kallus

"The Long-Term Impact of Financial Literacy: Evidence from Community College" (funding secured, piloting stage)
with Junru Lyu

PRESENTATIONS: (*presented by a coauthor)

November 2026	SEA 96th Annual Meeting, Houston, TX
September 2026	SITE Psychology and Economics, Stanford, CA
July 2026	NBER Summer Institute, Workshop on Aging, Cambridge, MA
July 2026	ESA (Economic Science Association) World Meeting, Los Angeles, CA*
June 2026	ASHE (American Society of Health Economists), Minneapolis, MN*
May 2026	BEAM (Behavioral Economics Annual Meeting), New Haven, CT
April 2026	Stanford Financial Education Symposium, Stanford, CA (poster)
January 2026	ASSA, Philadelphia, PA*
September 2025	Advances with Field Experiments (AFE) Conference, Chicago, IL*
June 2025	ASHE, Nashville, TN*

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE:

RESEARCH:

Research Assistant to Professor Terrance Odean, U.C. Berkeley (Summer 2023)
Research Assistant to Professor Manisha Padi, U.C. Berkeley (Summer 2022)

TEACHING:

Graduate Student Instructor, Haas School of Business, U.C. Berkeley (Spring 2024, 2025)
EWMBA 201B Macroeconomics (Prof. Wilcox).
Graduate Student Instructor, Department of Economics, U.C. Berkeley (2023)
ECON 119 Psychology and Economics (Prof. Taubinsky).
Teaching Assistant, Department of Economics, Georgetown University (2014–2016)
ECON 001 Introduction to Microeconomics (2015–2016)
ECON 002 Introduction to Macroeconomics (2014–2015)

INDUSTRY:

BlackRock, Insurance Portfolio Management Team, New York, NY (2016–2021)
Fixed income portfolio management for Financial Institutions Group (FIG) team

FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS:

2026	Stone Center on Wealth and Income Inequality Dissertation Fellowship	($17,000)
2026	National Endowment for Financial Education (NEFE) Research Grant	($35,000)
2025	Stanford Institute for Financial Decision-Making (IFDM) Grant	($10,000)
2025	Stone Center on Wealth and Income Inequality Dissertation Fellowship	($17,000)
2025	J-PAL Health Care Delivery Initiative (HCDI) Research Grant	($50,000)
2025	J-PAL Social Policy Research Initiative (SPRI) Research Grant	($50,000)
2025	Institute for Business & Social Impact Research Grant	($29,000)
2025	Robert Wood Johnson Foundation Racial Inequalities in Health Research Grant	($25,000)
2025	Xlab Graduate Student Research Funding	($4,000)
2024	Outstanding Graduate Student Instructor Award (awarded first semester of teaching)	
2024	Commonwealth Fund Research Grant	($50,000)
2024	Fisher Center Research Fellowship	($15,000)
2024	UC Berkeley Law, Economics, and Politics Research Fellowship	($9,500)
2024	Economics Department Summer Research Funding	($1,600)
2023	Fisher Center Research Fellowship	($15,000)
2023	UC Berkeley Law, Economics, and Politics Research Fellowship	($6,500)
2023	Burch Center for Inequality Place Based Policy Fellowship	($10,000)
2023	University of California Consumer Credit Panel (UC-CCP) Access Funding *with Tudor Schlanger*	($8,000)
2022	Fisher Center Research Fellowship	($15,000)
2022	UC Berkeley Law, Economics, and Politics Research Fellowship	($9,000)
2021	National Science Foundation (NSF) Graduate Research Fellowship	
2016	Leslie H. Jacobson Medal for Best Thesis in the International Political Economy Major	
2014	Benjamin A. Gilman International Scholar	
2014	Georgetown University Honors Research Seminar, Krogh Scholar	

OTHER INFORMATION:

Referee:	American Economic Review, Journal of Public Economics
Service:	Graduate Economics Association (GEA) Co-Chair (2022–2023)
Mentoring:	GEA PhD Student Mentor (2022–present)
	Undergraduate Research Assistant Program (URAP) (2022–present)
Software:	Stata, Python, R, Bloomberg, Thomson Reuters Eikon, LaTeX
Languages:	English, Mandarin Chinese
Certifications:	FINRA Series 7 and 63 (2016–2021); Passed Level I of the CFA Exam
Citizenship:	United States